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Graduate Recruitment Team

Squarepoint Capital

London

Dear Sir or Madam,

I am applying for the Junior Discretionary Trader role in London. I am a final-year Economics student at the University of Strathclyde, graduating in summer 2027 with a predicted 2:1. Squarepoint's discretionary trading team, which runs strategies across equities, commodities, rates, FX and credit, offers the chance to learn judgement-led trading inside a firm built on systematic research.

My work keeps returning to one question: does an apparent edge survive a proper test? I tested CAPM on 704 anomaly portfolios across 56 countries and rejected zero alpha jointly in 48 of 52, with momentum the most persistent anomaly. My dissertation, supervised by Dr Luigi Gifuni, forecasts European gas volatility with mixed-frequency (MIDAS) models built on storage, market and news-based data, evaluates them out-of-sample against HAR and AR benchmarks, and asks whether better forecasts improve a volatility-targeted TTF futures strategy. As co-founder of the Strathclyde Agricapital Society, I also built a wheat calendar-spread strategy whose weekly backtest returned a Sharpe ratio of 0.76 before costs and 0.28 after, which taught me how quickly turnover erodes an edge.

Hedge funds appeal to me because the distance between an idea and its consequences is short: a research view becomes a position, and the position is marked every day. I take that accountability seriously. My lifetime poker winnings of over £40,000 came from respecting variance and sizing risk to a strict 50-buy-in bankroll rule, and as Treasurer of the Agricapital Society, which I helped grow to 126 members, I manage its budget and accounts.

Squarepoint stands out to me because it is expanding its discretionary business alongside its systematic core, so junior traders learn portfolio monitoring, maintenance and hedging from senior traders while working beside quantitative researchers. My own work moves between the two, systematic tests of factor premia and a rules-based wheat spread on one side and judgement about gas market news on the other, and I would like to learn where a discretionary trader adds value that a model cannot.

I would welcome the opportunity to discuss my application. Thank you for your time and consideration.

Yours faithfully,

Will McGowan